CentOS 7 now available

The CentOS Project has announced the general availability of CentOS 7, the first release of the free Linux distro based on the source code for RedHat Enterprise Linux (RHEL) 7. It is the first major release after the collaboration between the CentOS Project and Red Hat. CentOS 7 is built from the freely available RHEL 7 source code tree. The features closely resemble that of Red Hat's latest operating system. Just like RHEL 7, it is now powered by version 3.10.0 of the Linux kernel, with a default file system. It is also the first version to include a management engine, systemd, dynamic firewall system called the firewalld, and the boot loader, GRUB2.

The default Java Development Kit has also been upgraded to OpenJDK 7, and the system now ships with open VMware tools and 3D graphics drivers, out-of-the-box. Also, like RHEL 7, this is the version of CentOS that claims to offer an in-place upgrade path. Soon, users will be able to upgrade from CentOS 6.5 to CentOS 7 without reformatting their systems.

The CentOS team has launched a new build process, in which the entire distro is built from code hosted at the CentOS Project's own Git repository. Source code packages (SRPMs) are created as a side effect of the build cycle, and will be hosted on the main CentOS download servers.

Disc images of CentOS 7, which include separate builds for the GNOME and KDE desktops, a live CD image and a network-installable version, are also now available.

Google to launch Android One smartphones with MediaTek chipset

Google made an announcement about its Android One program at the recent Google I/O 2014, San Francisco, California. The company plans to launch devices powered by Android One in India first, with companies like Micromax, Spice and Karbonn. Android One has been launched to reduce the production costs of phones. The manufacturers mentioned earlier will be able to launch US$ 100 phones based on this platform. Google will handle the software part, using Android One. So phones will get firmware updates directly from Google. This is surprising because low budget phones usually don't receive any software updates. Sundar Pichai, Android head at Google, showcased a Micromax device at the show. The Micromax Android One phone has an 11.43 cm (4.5 inch) display, FM radio, SD card slot and dual SIM slot. Google has reportedly partnered with MediaTek for chipsets to power the Android One devices. We speculate that it is MediTek's MT6575 dual core processor that has been packed into Micromax's Android One phone.

It is worth mentioning here that 78 per cent of the smartphones launched in Q1 of 2014 were priced around US$ 200 in India. So Google's Android One will definitely herald major changes in this market. Google will also provide manufacturers with guidelines on hardware designs. And it has tied up with hardware component companies to provide high volume parts to manufacturers at a lower cost in order to bring out budget Android smartphones.

A rare SMS worm is attacking your Android device!

Android does get attacked with Trojan apps that have no self-propagation mechanism, so users don't notice the malfunction. But here's a different, rather rare, mode of attack that Android devices are now facing. Selfmite is a SMS worm attack. It is the second of such deadly viruses found in the past two months. Selfmite automatically sends SMSs to the users with their name in the message. The SMS contains a shortened URL which triggers users to install a third part APK file called TheSelfTimerV1.apk. The SMS says, "Dear [name], Look the Self-time.." Some remote server hosts this malware application. Users can find SelfTimer installed in the app drawer of their Android devices.

The Selfmite worm shows a pop-up to download mobogenie_122141003.apk, which offers synchronisation between Android devices and PCs. The app has over 50 million downloads on Play Store, but all are through various paid referral schemes and promotion programmes. Researchers at Adaptive Mobile believe that a number of Mobogenie downloads are promoted through some malicious software used by an unknown advertising platform. A popular vendor of security solutions in North America detected dozens of devices that were infected with Selfmite. The attack campaign was launched using Google. The short linked URL of this malicious app was distributed in the Google shortlink format. The APK link was visited 2,140 times. Later, Google disabled it.

Android devices detect apps from unknown and unauthorised developers. But some users enable installation authentication even for apps from 'unknown sources'. Their devices become the targets for worms like this.